

Practice Paper 32 — Answer Scheme

Paper 2 — Comprehension

Sections B & C

Note to teachers and students

- Marks are awarded for **meaning**, not for exact words. Where a quotation is required, it has been indicated in inverted commas.
- Where the question asks for **own words**, a candidate who lifts directly from the text receives **zero** for that mark unless the lifted phrase is unavoidable.
- For language and tone questions, accept any reasonable alternative that clearly fits the textual evidence.

Section B — Text 3 Answer Scheme [20 marks]

Q1. [2] — Mother's careful preparation

1 mark each for any two of:

- She had written the instructions out **twice** (once on blue paper, once on the back of the ticket).
- The instructions were specific and detailed (“Do not get off before Halton Junction”; “Do not speak to anyone you do not know”; “If lost, find a guard in a red cap”).
- The writing was in her “small, careful hand”, showing attention to detail.
- She had ensured he had his suitcase on the rack and his sandwiches with him.

Q2. [1] — “Perfectly capable”

1 mark — The mother wanted her son to feel **confident** / **grown-up** / **trusted** / **reassured** before he set off alone; she was trying to **steady his nerves** and convince him that he could manage the journey by himself.

Q3. [2] — Lack of being looked at

1 mark — He had expected to feel embarrassed by being **stared at**, but instead found that being **ignored** / **invisible** was worse.

1 mark — This shows his **loneliness** / **self-consciousness** / **anxiety**: as a boy travelling alone for the first time, he wanted, at some level, to be **acknowledged** by the adults around him, and their indifference made him feel small and out of place.

Q4. [2] — “Legs as long as a man's”

1 mark — He was trying to **appear older** / **more grown-up** than he really was.

1 mark — It suggests he felt **small and childish** in adult company and was self-consciously **imitating** adult posture in order to be taken seriously. (Accept: he was trying to **hide his nervousness**.)

Q5. [2] — Eating the sandwich early

1 mark — The reason: eating “gave [him] something to do with [his] hands.”

1 mark — It reveals that he was **nervous** / **restless** / **uncomfortable**, and was looking for any small action to **occupy himself** and **steady his anxiety**.

Q6. [2] — The old gentleman’s manner

1 mark — He was **polite** and **formal**, treating the boy with the **seriousness one would show an adult** (“grave politeness”, “young man”).

1 mark — At the same time he was **reserved** / **undemonstrative**: he returned to his paper as soon as he had asked his single question, as though **acknowledging** the boy was enough without making a fuss of him.

Q7. [2] — Why “adult” is significant

1 mark — Tea, or coffee, is a drink associated with **grown-ups**, not children; it represents the world the boy is **not yet part of**.

1 mark — The word reveals that part of the **attraction** of stepping off the train was the chance to **do something adult himself** — a temptation strong enough to override his mother’s strict instructions.

Q8. [2] — “Slow cold horror”

(a) [1]: Horror is usually a **sudden, hot** feeling, so combining it with **slow** and **cold** is unexpected — the words usually describe physical temperature and pace, not an emotion.

(b) [1]: It suggests his reaction was not panic but a **gradually dawning, paralysing dread** — the realisation crept over him before he could move or breathe.

Q9. [2] — The old gentleman’s remark

1 mark — The short, dry comment shows that he had been **quietly watching over** the boy the whole time, even while pretending to read.

1 mark — His decision **not to make a fuss** of the incident, and to return immediately to his paper, shows his **tact** / **kindness without embarrassment** — he respects the boy’s dignity.

Q10. [2] — “A small examination”

1 mark — The boy felt that he had been **informally tested** by the events at Crewe and had **passed** — he had handled an adult problem on his own.

1 mark — The other passengers had **recognised** this without saying so directly; he had been **accepted** by them, in a small way, as one of their company rather than as a child.

Q11. [2] — “Tried not to look too pleased”

1 mark — He feels **proud** of having travelled by himself and managed the journey successfully.

1 mark — He is trying to **hide** his pride, because an adult would not show such pleasure openly — which itself reveals his **new sense of grown-up self-control** and **quiet satisfaction**.

Section C — Text 4 Answer Scheme [25 marks]

Q12. [2] — “No field at all”

1 mark — Traditionally, sport was understood as a **physical activity** taking place on a **pitch, court or field**, involving running, hitting or throwing.

1 mark — A sports editor of 1985 would have been **baffled** by the idea that the most-watched competition could involve **people sitting at desks in front of computer screens**, since this would not have been recognised as “sport” at all.

Q13. [1] — Tone of “in the wrong place”

1 mark — **Wry / dryly humorous / gently ironic.** (Accept: **amused, tongue-in-cheek.**) The writer is **mocking** the assumption that sport must be physical — he is not really saying eSports players are “wrong”, but pointing out how **old definitions** fail to fit them.

Q14. [2] — Ways eSports players earn money

1 mark each for any two of:

- **Tournament prize money**, funded by game publishers and sponsors (e.g. forty million US dollars at The International 2021).
- **Team salaries** paid by professional organisations (ranging from modest five-figure sums to seven-figure contracts).
- **Sponsorships and endorsements** — peripheral manufacturers, energy drinks, broadband providers — which are often the **largest source** of income.

Q15. [2] — “Ancient at twenty-five”

(a) [1]: **Ancient** normally describes someone **very old** (eighty or ninety), not a person of twenty-five who is in fact still **young** in ordinary life.

(b) [1]: In eSports, **reaction times decline** from the early twenties and the games themselves **change so rapidly** that a player of twenty-five is past his physical and competitive peak — so by the standards of the industry he genuinely is **old**.

Q16. [2] — Reasons eSports careers are short

1 mark each for any two of:

- **Reaction times** (measured in milliseconds) **decline** from the early twenties onwards.
- A **software update / patch** can erase the technical advantage a player has spent years building.
- The games themselves **change faster than human reflexes** can adapt.
- The industry data: most careers last **between four and seven years**; many last fewer than three.

Q17. [2] — “The dream is to be watched”

1 mark — The **goal** of young players has **shifted** from **competitive achievement** (winning championships) to **audience attention** (being viewed on a streaming platform).

1 mark — This reveals that the eSports industry is now driven less by **sporting glory** and more

by **entertainment and audience economics** — a streamer with no titles can earn more than a mid-table tournament player.

Q18. [2] — Training, streaming and sleeping

1 mark — Their **working and personal lives** have **no clear boundary**: they live, work and rest in the **same building**, often for twelve to fourteen hours a day.

1 mark — This suggests an **unhealthy, exhausting** lifestyle that lacks rest, privacy or balance — conditions which lead directly to **burnout** and physical injury, as the case of Faker illustrates.

Q19. [1] — Small fraction of working players

1 mark — The writer mentions this to show that **unionisation in eSports is still very limited**: even the most established players' association **covers only a small minority** of professional players, so most eSports workers remain **without collective protection**.

Q20. [2] — “Predictably”

1 mark — The word suggests the writer is **unsurprised** — he **expected** publishers to oppose the rule.

1 mark — It implies a **quietly critical / cynical** view: publishers put **commercial interest** (their youngest, most marketable stars) **ahead of the welfare** of those teenagers, and this is, to the writer, the **predictable behaviour** of the industry.

Q21. [2] — The closing image

1 mark — The image **personalises** the abstract industry: instead of statistics, the reader is left with **one specific figure** — a teenager at a desk — which is **vivid and memorable**.

1 mark — The contrast between the **boy** (“teenager”, “headphones”) and the **vast audience** (“six million strangers”) **encapsulates** the central paradox of the article — that eSports has made **ordinary children** into **global performers** — and invites the reader to consider whether this is **acceptable**.

Q22. Summary [13 marks total: 6 content + 7 style]

Content points ($\frac{1}{2}$ mark each, max 6 marks). **Eight available content points; candidates should aim for all 8.**

How professional eSports players earn money (Paragraphs 2 and 4):

1. **Tournament prize money**, funded by publishers and sponsors.
2. **Salaries** paid by professional team organisations.
3. **Sponsorship and endorsement deals** (often the largest source).
4. **Streaming income** from platforms such as Twitch and YouTube Gaming — subscriptions, donations and advertising.

Difficulties faced in their working lives (Paragraphs 3, 5 and 6):

5. Careers are **unusually short** — reaction times decline by the mid-twenties and games change faster than reflexes.

6. **Contracts are often negotiated by teenagers** without legal advice, against experienced lawyers.
7. **Working hours are excessive** (twelve to fourteen hours daily), causing **burnout** and physical injury.
8. **Concerns about age and welfare** — many players begin competing at fourteen or fifteen, raising questions about schooling and screen time.

Sample full-marks summary (78 words):

Professional eSports players earn money through tournament prize pools, salaries from professional teams, lucrative sponsorship deals and, increasingly, income from streaming platforms that pay through subscriptions, donations and advertising. However, their working lives are difficult: careers are short, since reflexes decline early and games change constantly. Teenagers sign contracts without legal advice, train for up to fourteen hours daily, and risk burnout or injury. Many begin competing before they are old enough to drive.

Length count: 78 words from “Professional” onwards.

— END OF ANSWER SCHEME —